



New Digital Horizons

Epson's a household name in the printers and projectors category. Mr. Minoru Usui, on his recent India visit, sat with us to give us a sense of where the industry's heading in the near future. Excerpts from our interview:

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Q Is India an important market for Epson? What are your specific plans for India in the next 5 years?

Yes of course, India is a very important market for Epson now, and it will continue to grow in importance. It's essential for Epson to listen carefully to the requirements of Indian customers, and to develop products that meet these needs. Part of my reason for visiting India this month and in the past has to speak to our local staff, visit customers and therefore directly obtain information about the Indian market and customers.

Q What is your view on 3D Printing? When will we see a consumer-grade affordable 3D printer in the market?

Epson is looking closely at the possibilities for 3D printing. Our original Micro Piezo inkjet technology is extremely versatile and certainly has potential for 3D and a wide range of other printing applications.

It's difficult to say exactly when such a printer will become readily available, but we will continue to review the market carefully and work hard to create products that meet the needs of our customers.

Q Traditional print industries are declining in growth, digital publishing is steadily increasing. As a printer manufacturer, how is this trend affecting you and the industry? The volume of output from commercial digital printing will grow by 400 per cent from 2010 to 2015. Epson's Micro Piezo



Minoru Usui, President, Seiko Epson Corporation

technology provides high speed, high reliability, and is kind to the environment. We have already started to leverage these advantages by creating printers for applications such as outdoor signage, commercial photo printing and packaging labels. We therefore believe we are well placed to take advantage of the shift to digital printing.

Printers using Micro Piezo technology are ideal for on-demand printing – exactly the right amount at the right time-printing, which we believe will continue to expand.

Q Is there an increased pressure demanding printer manufacturers to produce greener printers with minimal environmental impact? How are they different from a normal printer?

Yes, over the years we have taken a variety of measures to make our products greener including removing potentially harmful substances, making them easier to recycle and reducing their energy use.

In recent years environmental concerns have become especially become important in the office, and we have launched a range of business inkjet printers that have considerable environmental advantages over laser printers, including using around 90 per cent less electricity. In commerce too, for example, our SureLab product is aimed at high-street commercial photo shops. This product eliminates the harmful

chemicals used in conventional analog photo printing processes.

Q How will the printer industry shape up in the next decade? Could you give us any forecasts or predictions?

First, I believe we will see the steady expansion of inkjet printing in the office. Inkjet offers advantages over lasers in terms of running costs, first print out speed, and energy consumption, and it is Epson's task to make customers aware of the fantastic business inkjet printers we offer.

Second, as on-demand printing expands, we will see an acceleration of the shift to digital printing in commerce and industry. As mentioned above, Epson will step up its efforts to provide products that address actual needs in these areas.

Q Some of your 3D projectors are priced at similar price points as 3D Smart TVs. Is it fair to compare projectors with HDTVs? Which one is the better option for users and why?

It's not a straight comparison because projectors and TVs have different roles in home entertainment.

Large screen TVs may not be practical for some customers who have smaller living rooms, and are not cost effective at 80 inches and above. Certainly projectors are the better option when people want to enjoy entertainment at 100 inches and above.

Projectors are easy to set up and use, and can readily bring big screen entertainment to customers wanting to enjoy movies, sports and games.

Q Are projector sales according to your expectations?

While I am pleased with how customers have accepted our innovative projectors, I am never fully satisfied. We are always looking to improve sales by providing products with functions and features that address specific customer needs. Epson has been the world leading projector manufacturer for 11 years, and we are looking to build on the expertise and advantages we have gained to strengthen this position. **Q**